

KNOWLEDGE TRANSFER SESSION · VALIDATION

Formulating Your Validation Pipeline

From Assumptions to Evidence — without the false confidence.

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Brought by Phil · Unleash Ventures



Philipp Alexander Ströhemann

Project Unleash

BEFORE WE START

Housekeeping

**Mute your mic**

Stay muted unless invited to speak.

**Chat = engagement only**

Reactions & the audience-validating answers I'll ask for. **No questions in chat.**

**Questions → Slido**

Drop them in any time. We tackle as many as possible in the open Q&A.

**Vote on what matters**

Upvote the questions you want answered first. Pre-submitted gets priority.

Slido — submit & vote on questions

Link will be shared in chat. Pre-submitted questions get priority.

slido.com

TODAY'S PLAN

Agenda

- 3 min

What are you currently validating?

Quick audience check — in the chat, not show of hands
- 10 min

Why startups die — false positives + the Mom Test

The real killer, and the foundations
- 15 min

From talk to test — the Validation Ladder

How to design experiments that actually generate signal
- 5 min

What to try this week + Unleash

Concrete next moves. Where to go next.
- 25 min

Open Q&A

Your turn — bring the hard ones

YOUR SESSION HOST

Phil · Unleash



Philipp Alexander Ströhemann

Northern German. **Studied in South Africa back in 2014** — came to Cape Town for an MBA exchange. That's how I got here.

Co-founded **ComX** with South African partners. Exited to a German PE firm in **2022**.

Investing since 2021 — formalised in 2025 via **MVP Founders** (Germany) & **Project Unleash** (South Africa). Both *building camels, not unicorns*.

INVESTING

2–3 ventures per year. Very close work.

CAMELS, NOT UNICORNS

Resilient. Cash-flow first. Built for African reality.

IN THE CHAT

What are you currently validating?

TODAY'S TOPIC

Why do startups die?

Most founders get this wrong. The obvious answers aren't the real killer.

THE USUAL SUSPECTS

Common Answers



Bad Product

The feature set wasn't right.



Poor Team

Wrong people, wrong roles.



No Funding

Ran out of money.

*These are **symptoms**, not causes. The real killer shows up much earlier.*

THE REAL KILLER

False positives kill your company.

Every success is the sum of decisions taken on the information you source or receive. Bad info → wrong turn → wasted months → dead runway.

The equation

Quality of Decisions
= Quality of Information

WHAT FALSE POSITIVES LOOK LIKE

- "That's a great idea, you should build it." — friend being polite.
- "Yes, I'd use that." — hypothetical, not a commitment.
- "I'd pay for it." — until the credit card comes out.
- Survey responses without skin in the game.
- Your own excitement about your idea.

THE NAME OF THE GAME

Get the **right information**
ASAP
and
avoid false positives.

REFRAME

The "Validation Pipeline" Trap.

Most pipelines validate what you **want** to be true.

Pipelines feel safe. **Volume of "yes" replaces depth of evidence.**

The Mom Test is the discipline — the **un-pipeline**. Go deep on quality, not wide on quantity.

THE BOOK THAT SAVES FOUNDERS

The Mom Test — 4 principles



The Mom Test

Rob Fitzpatrick

*Required reading.
Read it this week.*

1. Founder = Truth-Seeking Machine

Avoid praise. Avoid validation. Find the answers that make you feel uncomfortable — those are the real ones.

2. Customer-Obsessed > Solution-Obsessed

Nobody cares about your idea. Everyone cares about their problem. Talk about *their* lived experience, not your product.

3. Each Call = a Learning Event

Open-ended questions. No pitch. You're here to discover, not to convince.

4. The Only Positive Feedback is 🌸

LOIs. Signed contracts. Sign-ups. Pre-orders. Words are not signal — money and commitment are.

STOP ASKING THESE

X

Poor Questions

Hypothetical. Polite-answer magnets. Noise, not signal.



THE QUESTIONS

"Would you use this?"

"Do you think this is a good idea?"

"Would you pay for this?"

"How much would you pay for this?"

"What features would you like?"

"If we built X, would that solve it?"

WHY THEY FAIL

It's a guess, not a fact.

People are polite — they'll say yes.

Hypothetical and socially pressured.

People don't know until they pay.

You're outsourcing product design.

Leading the witness.

ASK THESE INSTEAD

✓

Strong Questions

Anchored in real behaviour. They surface pain, budget, and who actually decides.



THE QUESTIONS

"Tell me about the last time you did [X]?"

"How are you currently solving this?"

"What tools are you using today?"

"What's the hardest part about [X]?"

"Why did you stop using [other solution]?"

"Who else is involved in this process?"

WHAT THEY REVEAL

Anchored in reality — real workflow.

Surfaces alternatives + pain level.

Exposes budget, process, habits.

Pain and priorities, clearly.

Frustrations & switching triggers.

Maps buying roles + internal org.

FROM TALK → TEST

The Validation Ladder

Skin in the game = right info. *Not all answers are valued equally.*

1	Problem Interview Open conversation. No pitch. Just listen.	30 minutes of their time. Aim for the real workflow, real pain, real alternatives.	RECENT FOUNDING INVESTMENT — EXAMPLE <i>"Walk me through your last 3 mornings — what happened?"</i>
2	Solution Sketch Mock · wireframe · one-pager. Then <i>open-ended</i> follow-ups — never yes/no.	Their attention + opinion. Aim for substitution behaviour — what they'd actually swap out.	RECENT FOUNDING INVESTMENT — EXAMPLE <i>Show 3-screen mock. Then: "Walk me through how you'd use this in your morning."</i>
3	 Demand Test Pitch · landing page · qualify hard · LOI / deposit.	Their money or reputation. Aim for whether they actually buy.	RECENT FOUNDING INVESTMENT — EXAMPLE <i>Pitch → landing page → leave a number → qualify hard → LOI / deposit.</i>
4	MVP / Workflow Commit Post-deal use — they commit time AND money.	Behaviour change. Aim for retention, repeat use, referrals.	RECENT FOUNDING INVESTMENT — EXAMPLE <i>Once signed: usage week-on-week, retention, peer referrals.</i>
 SOURCES · Steve Blank — Customer Development · Eric Ries — Lean Startup · Rob Fitzpatrick — Mom Test · YC pre-launch playbook  WHAT'S GOOD · Forces escalating commitment · Each rung has a clear next move · Can't fake skin in the game  WHAT TO CHALLENGE · Linear assumptions don't apply everywhere · Stage & segment can change the climb order · Each rung has its own false positives — deposits ≠ retention			

DESIGNING EXPERIMENTS

What is a good test?

Four rules. If a test misses any of them, it's theatre — not evidence.

1

Skin in the game

The other side has to **spend something** — money, time, reputation, calendar block. No skin = no signal.

Example. *One €500 deposit beats 100 "I'd love this" replies on a Typeform.*

2

Falsifiable

Define **what counts as a "no"** before you run it. If every outcome confirms your hypothesis, it's not a test.

Example. *"If fewer than 3 of 10 SMBs sign the deposit — we kill the wedge." Said out loud. Before launch.*

3

Pre-defined success metric

Decide the **number that proves it works** in advance. "It went well" is not a metric.

Example. *"8 of 10 sign within 14 days = green light. 7 or fewer = re-design." Number written down. No moving the goalposts.*

4

Committed timeline

Set the **cut-off**. "We'll see" turns into 6 months of polite emails. Two weeks. Two months. Decide.

Example. *"We launch the demand test on Monday the 12th. We decide by Monday the 26th. Either way."*

Try this now: take your most recent test — benchmark it against these four. If it misses any, you ran *theatre*, not a test.

WHEN PIPELINES GO WRONG

Pitfalls

 Surveys without skin

100 hypothetical responses are worth less than **one signed LOI**.
Seen this week: *founder showed me a 200-response Typeform with 80% "yes." None of them have ever paid for anything similar.*

 Friend bias

Your network will tell you it's brilliant. They love you. They're **not the customer**.
Watch out: *if your first 10 conversations were all with people who'd answer your WhatsApp on a Sunday — you have noise, not data.*

 Builder bias

You spent a year on this. You will **find evidence** it works. That's not validation, that's confirmation.
Tell: *36+ months in and you're still narrowing the niche to make the problem "fit". You'll always find a tinier niche if you squint — but in the AI era, if it took you that long, the problem probably isn't that big. Be honest about whether to carry on.*

 Premature pricing

Asking "what would you pay?" before they want it gives you **fiction priced as data**.
Test: *until somebody signs a deposit, every price quote is a guess — theirs and yours.*

 Scaling the wrong thing

10 great conversations > 50 mediocre ones. Don't industrialise **before you've found the truth**.
Symptom: *hiring a BDR before product-market fit. Building a CRM dashboard before you have 10 buyers to track.*

THINGS TO TAKE WITH YOU

What to try this week

Benchmark yourself. Then pick up the phone.

The single best benchmark for whether you're really validating: **how many 1:1 customer conversations did you have this month?** Less than 10? You're not doing it enough. The bar is **five real conversations every single week**. Every week.

1

Count this month

How many 1-on-1 customer conversations did you actually have in the last 30 days? Be honest. **<10 = not enough**.

2

5 a week. Every week.

Use the **Strong Questions** from slide 12. No pitch. Just listen. The Mom Test is short — download it, or run it through Claude in 10 minutes.

3

Climb one rung in 30 days

Design **one demand test** with skin in the game. LOI, deposit, paid pilot. Falsifiable. Time-boxed. Run it.

We've found that to build **cash-flow effective, VC-independent companies** — this discipline is the foundation. If that's the kind of company you're trying to build — **have a look at Unleash**.

IF THIS RESONATED

Have a look at **Unleash**.

We help founders build companies for the **South African reality**.

A **post-exit-led venture community** for early-stage companies building *resilient ventures*. We write our own cheques. **No LPs. No nonsense.**

If that's **you** — or somebody in your network — **send them our way**.

 **APPLY / SIGN UP**
unleash-ventures.com

 **SUBSTACK**
philunleashed.substack.com

 **LINKEDIN**
/in/phil-ber-cpt

Open Q&A

Your turn — bring the hard ones.
What's the rung you're stuck on?

Thank You.

Go talk to 5 customers this week. The truth is on the other side of an honest conversation.

 EMAIL

pas@pas-ventures.com

 LINKEDIN

/in/phil-ber-cpt

 UNLEASH

unleash-ventures.com